There is little that Ratan would have been happy with in his meeting with Lord Mandelson. When they met, the latter bluntly queried, ‘Why did you come to me?’ When Ratan replied, ‘You own most of the banks, so give us access to credit because we have nowhere to turn,’ the secretary’s reaction was confounding. He told Ratan, ‘You are an Indian company. Go to the Indian banks.’ Ratan was taken aback as the ‘jobs were English’.

He was not the only one who was exasperated with the reaction of the Gordon Brown government. An affected employee’s sister had written to Ratan, expressing her regret at the Teesside plant being shut down and her pain at the government’s lack of seriousness in helping the company. She wrote, ‘I am most disappointed in Gordon Brown for not supporting Tata Steel as other European governments have done.’

For a company sworn to social corporate responsibility and with a reputation for caring for communities integral to its business, the decision to stop work at Teesside was indeed painful. Ratan replied to her explaining all that he had done to seriously keep the company afloat. He said that he had kept it open for nine months trying to find a way out and had incurred a loss of £150 million in the process. In his quintessential style, he pleaded with her to understand his predicament saying: ‘Believe me, my heart is as heavy as yours in knowing that there was no option but to mothball the Teesside plant.’

Ratan continued his efforts to salvage the assets Tata Steel had bought. As he was trying to revive them, he also looked for opportunities to find a suitable buyer for some of the plants. Shutting down a facility was his last resort. He worked hard to avoid any situation that would cause hardship to the company staff and their families. With this objective, on 27 August 2010, an MoU was signed with the Thailand-based steel producer Sahaviriya Steel Industries (SSI) to sell the partially mothballed Teesside Cast Products plant for $500 million. It was a ‘high-cost production’ plant and was just not structurally viable, says Chatterjee.

The effort at restructuring the UK operations continued in right earnest. In September 2010, Corus was rebranded as Tata Steel Europe. In 2012, it announced a plethora of steps to achieve the goal. It aimed at making the company an ‘all-weather’ steel producer. The steps included modernization of and restarting a steel furnace in Port Talbot. The plant, whose steel was used in almost all the UK-made cars, was to be modernized at a cost of £250 million. Other steps included reorganizing management and